



Pocket art studios

Top apps for design, video, art of all kind

We live in a golden age of creativity – but it’s easy to forget that your smartphone already has everything you need to design, draw, compose, animate, or edit at a surprisingly professional level. You don’t need Adobe subscriptions, expensive microphones, or studio gear. What you need is the right set of tools – and that’s where these ten apps come in.

This chapter is a showcase of mobile apps that empower you to create across a range of media – from photography to music to animation to AI art. Most of these aren’t mainstream, yet they offer functionality rivaling (or beating) well-known desktop tools. And nearly all of them are fully free, ad-light, or open-source.

Whether you’re sketching a comic, mixing a song, editing a vlog, or reviving old photos – these are the apps that bring your imagination to life.

1. Snapseed

Platforms: Android, iOS

A pro-grade photo editor in disguise, with no ads or paywalls. Snapseed is Google’s quietly brilliant photo editing app that somehow flies under the radar, even though it offers 29+ tools and filters including Tune Image, Curves, Healing, HDR Scape, Selective Adjust, and a powerful RAW editor. While most mobile editors focus on presets and gimmicky effects, Snapseed gives you precise control over exposure, detail, tone, and texture.

It’s particularly powerful for people who want more than just Instagram filters – Snapseed feels like Lightroom Lite, but with zero learning curve.

The “Stacks” feature lets you review and modify each step of your edit, like non-destructive layers – a feature usually reserved for desktop apps.